Hopes, Expectations, and Vision

Senior Practicum: ED 449

Fall 2022

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My Vision and Focus for the Course

Welcome to the most fulfilling, most enriching, most challenging class I can imagine.

Every class has a syllabus—some kind of dry, boring document that tells you about standards and policies and what awful thing awaits you if you submit an assignment late. Well, that's not this document. I'll make one in case an administrator knocks, but this document is the real heart of the course. This is where I give you a taste of what this is all really about.

When we speak of rigor we normally think of hours of homework or difficulty of text, but senior practicum is more rigorous than any of that: it's not merely hard work, but *heart work*. This class will change you.

It will make you into a teacher. Jesus grew "grace for grace" and "line upon line."[1] So will you.

The heart of any good class is its questions. Here are mine.

- What is school really for?
- What difference does a great teacher make?
- What is the character of a great teacher?
- What will it take to become a masterful teacher?
- In what ways is teaching a holy art?
- For what do I have to be grateful to BYUI?
    - How is BYUI unique in its vision for education?
    - What does it mean to be a "place of educational innovation perpetually?"

Have you noticed that great questions are more thrilling than great answers? I invite you to ponder these questions—to write them on your heart, as it were, and to think on them day and night. I can't promise we'll answer them fully, but I can promise that you'll thrill with the chance to ask them.

And if there is anything in this class that isn't directly tied to one of these questions—especially the one about how to become a masterful teacher—then you say the word, and it's gone. Any homework assignment or bit of classwork that isn't aligned, I'll cancel it. Everything—I mean everything—that isn't aligned with those questions isn't worth our time.

So whatever standards and outcomes I may put over there for the department and the university and the state accreditors, here are my most honest "educational outcomes" for this class:

1. Course participants will see the path toward the character and effectiveness of masterful teachers—and will begin to walk it;
2. And they will begin to understand the unique mission of BYUI in developing, (and their unique charge in becoming) educational leaders and innovators, who change lives in the hands of God.

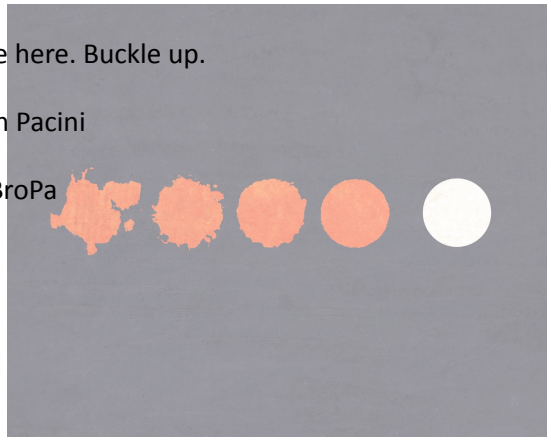
It's worth taking a moment to compare this to the mission statement of the Department of Early, Elementary, and Special Education:

"Follow the example of the Savior to become outstanding educators who empower learners to reach their divine potential." By the way, that's my job too. My goal is to help you reach your divine potential.

I'm so glad you're here. Buckle up.

Brother Benjamin Pacini

But just call me BroPa



[1] See John 1, 2nd Peter 1, and D&C 4.

Rigor, Reality, and Investment

This class is an enormous investment—you'll grow in ways you never anticipated. At the same time, the sheer amount of work and stress are a challenge. You'll need to be at your very peak to excel. I want you to take some time and make sure you are prepared to really pull this off. I do not recommend this course to anyone who is taking more than 12 credits or doing more than 15 hours of outside work. In fact, even that is too much for some. On the other hand, some students have told me how grateful they are to be taking only the one class during the semester. Keep in mind that in addition to homework and time in schools, you will also be preparing your senior portfolio during this semester.



At the same time I trust you. You know your limits. But understand—this will be unlike any course you have ever taken. It's not unusual for there to be tears and hard things—and also incredible joy and growth.

This isn't just about passing the class—it's about finding the joy in it all. It's about the thrill of growing. I don't doubt that my overachievers could pull off 15 credits—but would they enjoy every moment? Would they grow to their maximum potential, and experience what this class was really designed for? I want you to be able to spend time thinking about how excited you are for a delicious lesson with students the next day—not just worrying about keeping up with assignments.

At times, we all encounter unanticipated complications in life, whether it's challenges in our families, mental health issues, or unexpectedly challenging coursework. If at any point you feel like completing the course this semester will be too much, just reach out to me as early as you can so we can be proactive in helping you. In the worst case, you'll only be asked to repeat the course—and get more experience working with kids along the way.

Defining Success

Keep in mind that this is the first class you have likely ever taken in which you can pass and still be asked to repeat the course. In order to move on to student teaching, the following requirements need to be met:

- Pass the class with a C- or better.
- Submit a unit plan that is to standard.
- Score above 2 in all dispositions areas.
- Score above 2 in all Danielson domains.
- Create, submit, and defend a portfolio successfully, including the portfolio interview.

Of course there are some who are able to do all this and still struggle in the classroom—just as there are some who could succeed without so many requirements. On balance, however, these requirements are an excellent gauge of whether a teacher-candidate is ready to take their own classroom.

Course policies:

It is no small thing to demonstrate the dispositions of excellent teaching. While in my other courses I allow for late assignments and tend toward flexibility, this course is designed differently—and is designed to mimic the expectations of excellent teaching as a profession.

As such, the policies for this class are strict without being severe. They are built to help you succeed, but without lowering the bar for quality and excellence. Ultimately, it will be my discretion to judge whether a student has demonstrated professional dispositions—but course policies are meant to support precisely that kind of professionalism.

- **Late Policy:** Any work you submit that is your best efforts can be resubmitted until you earn the desired grade. As a matter of professionalism and dispositions, late work will not be accepted; you should speak with me in any event, however. You can still improve your grade, though you will take a hit on dispositions.

- **Attendance policy:** Course attendance is mandatory. Any classes missed are required to be made up, and no more than 1 seminar and 2 practicum days may be made up total. Exceptions will be judged on a case-by-case basis only, but are not often approved.
- **Substitute teaching:** Substitute teaching is one of the very best preparation practices that a teacher candidate can receive. Please be aware, however, that there are policies around substitute teaching that require that **any substitute teaching be approved by me**. If you have questions, see me.
- **Course books:** You will need access to three books, listed in the course booklist: Teach Like a Champion (TLAC), SEL and the Brain (SELATB), and Teaching as Leadership (TAL). TLAC can be any version 2.0 or higher. You can rent, buy, or borrow any of these, and access them online or in hardcopy—but you are expected to have access to them and read them thoroughly. While not required, I recommend you purchase your own copy for reference in your classroom.
- **Placement policies**: placement will be explained in class. You will be allowed to drive yourself or carpool, but I strongly recommend you carpool—students report that car groups are emotionally and professionally crucial to their development. Any arrangements regarding gas money, meeting times, or communication are up to the carpool group—even though they'll be decided in class. Note: You are responsible for deciding on norms and holding your group accountable for them.

Assignments & Projects

You'll find more detailed instructions about each of the assignments in I-Learn. But here's the basic overview of the assignments due each week and how long they should take:

- **Attendance Checks** (10 minutes weekly, plus time in class).
  - We become great teachers by learning from each other—and seminars are where we do that. Active, eager participation are expected. I hope this class is lively and thrilling—but it will be that way because you bring good things to the table. Attendance checks require you to show evidence of what you have learned through notes, a recorded video, or by other means.
  - In class, you should take notes every day on the most important things you learn. You will be expected to grade your attendance and provide notes as evidence that you paid attention, learned, and have grown.
  - You will be required to create a learning journal, online blog, or website of some kind to keep all of your learning in one place. We will discuss this in class.
- **Weekly Readings** (Roughly 2 hours per week.)
  - Weekly readings are significant in terms of workload. My greatest fear is that they will turn into requirements rather than an impetus for growth and improvement in the classroom. The best way to do this is by reading for 20-30 minutes every day. If you do and don't finish the readings, let me know and I can help you!
  - Like with attendance checks, you'll be expected to grade yourself and provide notes as evidence. You'll also need to come to class ready to answer oral exam questions and actively participate in class discussions.

- **Weekly Assignments** (2-3 hours per week; can be done during school hours)
  - The only category of assignment that can be done during school hours are the weekly assignments. These include observations and reflections. They are significant in workload. Students should review the expectations for the week early (probably Monday of the week it is due.

An example of how to successfully structure a typical week of work in this class:

A typical week:	Time on Assignment
Attendance Check (AC)	If you take good notes, this is just 10 minutes to upload on Saturday!
Weekly readings	Easiest way is to regularly read 20-30 minutes each night before bed—make sure to take good notes!
Weekly assignments	Make sure to review for ten minutes early in the week so you can plan out your time. Then, complete for 30 minutes during planning time each day.
UPOD	These take time, but are a part of great planning. I'd spend about 30 minutes each day to get them done—and polished! And if you need more time, see me or the TA!

- **UPOD Assignments** (1-2 hours total per week).
  - The final project for this course is the Unit Plan (which I jokingly call the Unit Plan of Doom, or UPOD). I have structured the assignments so that if you do them on schedule, they will be broken down into twelve bite-sized chunks.
  - Note: you will want to gather some things before they are due. These include student artifacts, pre-assessment data, and more. You should not start your unit unless you check with me.
  - The final UPOD will be submitted as one document that includes all the pieces of the assignment, a table of contents, and all final data and reflections.
  - The next line contains invisible text. Highlight it with your cursor to view the secret instructions.

Extra Credit Options: By now, you're a senior in college with a high degree of reliability, compliance, and professionalism. For those students who are looking to go above and beyond, there are things you can do to become an even more phenomenal future teacher, and they may help your grade a little too. Think of these as a menu of ways to accelerate your growth—even when you're out of my class, I hope they'll be useful! Consider the following:

- Contribute to the course. Speak with me about a project that will make the course better! Some students suggest better readings or videos; some review the syllabus or assignments; others restructure the assignments. All ideas welcome!
- Follow great teaching podcasts! The best learners are hungry for the best content—and nothing will make you a better teacher than listening to the best. I'm looking to build a library of the best teaching podcasts and would love your help!
- Tour a school or observe a master! No professional development is as good as observing the very best teachers and going to the best schools. Schedule a tour or observation and tell me what you learn!
- Join the education societies on campus—or attend a meeting or two! The Ed Societies are preparing students for future careers, and their activities are pretty great!
- Read a book! There are a thousand great books on teaching, and a great teacher is constantly devouring as many as they can get their hands on!
- Participate online! Ask questions, interact, and give your perspective on Twitter or in other social media venues.
- Innovate! If you have a solution, put it out there—and if it's good, get paid for it! A teacher that can design great learning should get it on Teachers Pay Teachers

Honor Code and Dress and Grooming

One of the things I have experienced in my life is working in schools that have no clear norms and expectations. I'm thrilled that I get to work at a place where they are clear and uplifting. We will review the honor code and dress and grooming standards in the first week, and will also review how they should be implemented in schools. You are expected to dress in conformity with the dress code, but also to do so with a positive attitude–and to espouse the principles of the honor code supportively. If a part of the dress code or honor code is a challenge for you, see me and we can work things out. There's nothing wrong with having differences, so long as they are expressed in the right way at the right time.

On Squeaking

Nothing brings me more joy than to have students come by (I'll always have candy and memes!) The squeaky wheel will get the grease—but it's your job to squeak if you need help! Come by anytime just to drop in, or feel free to email, text, or call to set up an appointment. I love using Zoom channels to communicate, but am happy to meet via zoom or in person too!

The most important rule with questions is ***just ask***—even if you think it's a silly question. I far prefer answering it than knowing people don't know what to do. If you can, though, try to consult course materials first, then a groupmate, then the zoom channel—and finally my TA, and then me. But more important than any of those is simply to squeak! Squeak my children!

- Email: pacinib@byui.edu. Phone: 443 803 0608. Zoom: 899-634-5818. Office: HIN 273.
- You should use my phone number. You're in college. It's allowed. That's why I gave it to you.
- Drop-In Hours: T/Th 12:30 - 2:00 PM. They're not office hours, they're drop-in hours. So drop in.
- I will also be generally available immediately following seminar for an hour or so. I'll also be at your schools all the time—let me know if you want me to pop by your classroom!

Personal Notes:

Emotional Health

One of my goals in this class is to help equip students with the habits, frame of mind, and resources to become resilient and emotionally strong. I believe strongly that creating emotionally strong, resilient students is about both decreasing stress, and increasing capacity. If discussions of emotional health are sensitive or difficult for you, please let me know as early as possible. I do not claim to have all the right ideas on this, but feel it to be important enough to bring up and discuss.

Additionally, I suspect that many of you lean toward perfectionism: teaching will help with that. You will learn, quickly, the art of "good enough." You should never feel the need to spend 3 hours on a 1 hour assignment. Be wise. Learn how to manage your own time carefully. Learn that excellence is better than perfectionism (including in grades) and know the difference between integrity and scrupulosity.

A thought on emotional health and grades: I hope all of you are aiming for an A. But I hope you realize that the real goal isn't the A, it's the learning--it's the success that you'll have in your classroom someday because of what you learned, the students' lives who will be changed, and the relationships you'll build with teachers, parents, students, and communities--and most importantly, the Lord. This is a very long-term game. You will see your success measured not in months, or even years, but decades and generations.

Sensitive Topics

The world is in tremendous turmoil. The devil is stirring men's hearts up unto anger, and it's hard to even have conversations on some topics. Elder Paul V. Johnson has asked faculty to have both "moral courage"

and “intellectual courage.” I do not believe that it is in your best interest for me to avoid difficult conversations. To the contrary, learning how to wrestle with difficult topics is one of the most important things you can take from your BYU-Idaho education. As such, I will attempt to do so with openness, sensitivity, and honesty. If there are questions that are important to you, don’t hesitate to ask me privately--and if appropriate, I may raise such issues in class, as well. I should also be clear that everything these days is politicized, and the only constant is anger. The solution is not to disagree less, but to disagree better. I do not expect you to agree with everything I say--I only expect respect and civility. In that context, I’m happy to discuss things that are pressing to you. I also am quite aware that I’m certainly wrong on some things—it doesn’t bother me. I hope it doesn’t bother you.

I also want to note just how deeply I believe in the gospel. I want anyone to feel welcome in my classroom, even if they aren’t sure about some part or another. Having said that, I hope it is clear how unapologetically I am on the side of the Lord and His church.

Art Note:
The artwork in this document is from Ben Crowder, a friend and favorite artist of mine. If you find the titles, you might see why I find them so important and meaningful. If you do, I would love to hear.